



Solomon Islands

The Solomons archipelago comprises several hundred coral reef islands scattered in the southwestern Pacific. Most of the population live on the six largest islands.



GEOGRAPHY

The six largest islands are volcanic, mountainous, and thickly forested. Flat coastal plains provide the only cultivable land.



CLIMATE

Northern islands are hot and humid all year round; farther south a cool season develops. November–April wet season brings cyclones.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

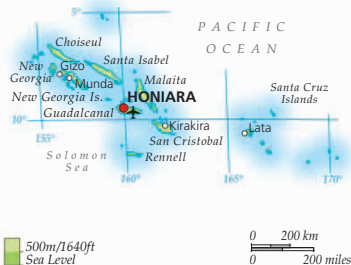
Almost all Solomon Islanders are Melanesian. Tensions are regional; Guadalcanal natives (Isatabu) fought against immigrant Malaitan workers in the 1998–2000 conflict, displacing thousands and ruining the economy. In 2003, Australian-led peacekeepers arrived to try to restore the rule of law. Outlying islands have pressed for autonomy. Animist beliefs exist alongside Christianity.



THE ECONOMY

Subsistence farming and fishing sustain 75% of people. Cash crops are copra and cocoa. Gold deposits. Civil conflict bankrupted the government, closed the main gold mine, and cut trade links. Forests have been depleted.

INSIGHT: *The battle for Japanese-held Guadalcanal was the first major US offensive in the Pacific War during World War II*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Solomon Islands

DATE OF FORMATION: 1978

CAPITAL: Honiara

POPULATION: 523,200

TOTAL AREA: 10,985 sq. miles
(28,450 sq. km)

DENSITY: 48 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, Pidgin English, Melanesian Pidgin, c. 120 others

RELIGIONS: Anglican 34%, Catholic 19%, other Protestant 38%, other 9%

ETHNIC MIX: Melanesian 94%, Polynesian 4%, other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Solomon Is. dollar = 100 cents